Indian-American rapper and singer Raja Kumari's new album, *The Bridge*, heralds the next stage of her sonic evolution. Compared to her previous work, there's a more introspective aspect to the lyrics, while musically, it's more pop and R&B-flavoured than her most well-known hip-hop hits.

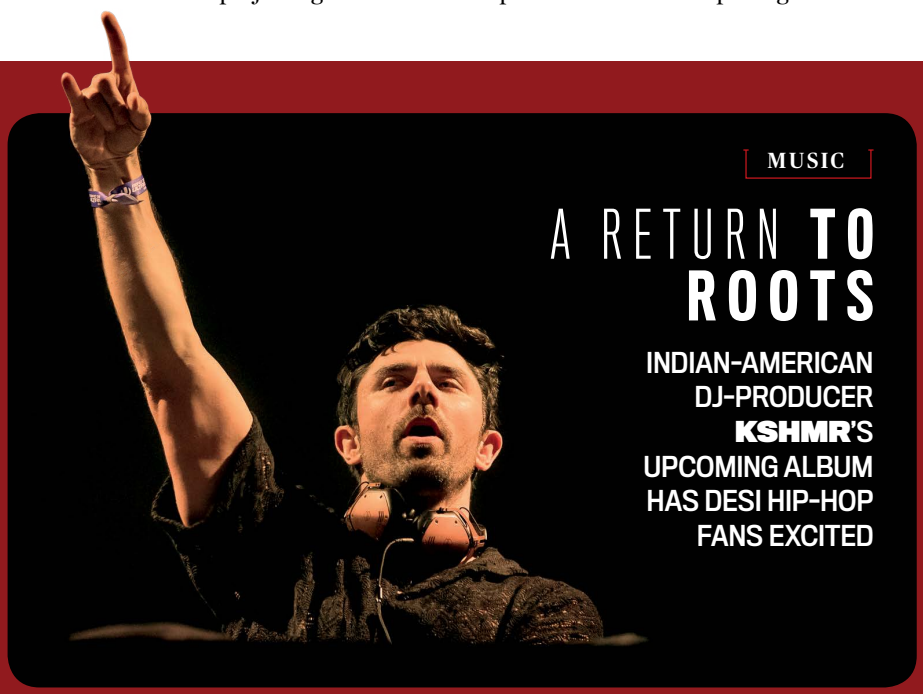
She chose to title the collection *The Bridge* because "not only is it bridging the West back to the East, it's also the bridge from who I was to where I am now," says Kumari over a Zoom call from her home in Los Angeles. "At the beginning of the album, there's a lot more rap, it's a little heavier, and then it just transforms to....a softer space."

Like many performing artists, Kumari—whose real name is Svetha Rao and who was born and raised in the US—re-evaluated her career during the pandemic. She spent the first few months in isolation in her apartment in LA and was "forced to deal with myself and all of my idiosyncrasies". This led her to realise that she was projecting a certain persona. "As someone who studies spirituality and Hindu mythology, I have this obsession with Ardhanarishvara, this balance between masculine and feminine energy," says Kumari. "I understood that I was [tapping into] my masculine [side]." The approach worked in her favour while navigating the male-dominated music industry, which is even more patriarchal in India than in the West. "I had to be so aggressive to cut through, but it was overloading my spirit. It was making me combative in different ways. [With this album], balance and integration has been the goal."

The Bridge has been released on Godmother Records, the independent label Kumari founded in 2021 after years of working with major music companies. From 2016 to 2019, she was signed to Sony Music-owned Epic, and from 2020 to 2021, to Mass Appeal India, which had a partnership with Universal Music. "I've learned from every situation," says Kumari, who has been candid about the tussles she's had with former labels. "I can't go back and say I wish I didn't do it. Because every opportunity provided me with something. I don't want to be submitted to all these random opinions about how to package me." Chief among those battles has been exactly how much to project her "Indianness" while marketing her as a global artist. An incident she has called out repeatedly in in-



"IT WAS TIMING, LUCK, ATTITUDE AND MUSIC," SAYS RAJA KUMARI ON BEING ABLE TO BREAK THROUGH THE DESI HIP-HOP SCENE DOMINATED BY MALE ARTISTS RAPPING IN HINDI OR REGIONAL LANGUAGES



MUSIC

A RETURN TO ROOTS

INDIAN-AMERICAN DJ-PRODUCER KSHMR'S UPCOMING ALBUM HAS DESI HIP-HOP FANS EXCITED

He's one of the top electronic dance music artists in the world, but for many Indian hip-hop fans, he's the man behind one of the most anticipated albums of 2023. Indian-American DJ-producer KSHMR (pronounced Kashmir), a.k.a. Niles Hollowell-Dhar, has been putting up pictures of himself recording with desi MCs on his social media for almost a year now, and their fans have been waiting to hear the results ever since.

KSHMR, a first-generation immigrant whose performance name pays tribute to his ancestral